

AP-27: Forced Propagation

Derivation Note D3.28 — Anti-Pattern Formalization

Series D, Phase D3 — Paper 3 Anti-Pattern Formalizations

Note #603 in the CKS Defensive-Publication Series

Taxonomy Category 7: Population-Scope Failures (Closing Note)

Author: Wenxin Li (Independent Researcher)

ORCID: 0009-0004-8065-3235

Date: May 15, 2026

License: Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 International (CC BY 4.0)

Attribution

This work derives from and formalizes the inter-Self coordination architecture introduced in “Inter-Self Coordination via Shared Substrate / Full Aspect Integration” (Li, April 2026), the third paper in the CKS theory series following “Coordination Outside the Model: A Human-Governed Substrate Pattern for AI Systems” (Li, April 2026) and “The Instinct/Reasoning Separation Outside the Model” (Li, April 2026).

Abstract

This note formalizes AP-27 (Forced Propagation), the third and final anti-pattern in Taxonomy Category 7 (Population-Scope Failures) of the Phase D3 series. Forced Propagation describes a governance failure in which a contributing Self conditions FAI participation on the receiving Self absorbing specific governance patterns — treating DNA absorption as a required outcome of inter-Self engagement rather than the receiving Self’s home governance decision. The architecture forecloses this failure mode by design: Paper 3 Claim 4 explicitly locates the DNA evolution locus within home governance, and no contributing Self holds authority to compel absorption. This note formalizes that architectural prohibition as prior art, identifies the detection criteria through which forced-propagation arrangements can be recognized, and draws the precise line between permissible contribution and impermissible compulsion. With AP-27, all 27 anti-patterns across all seven taxonomy categories in Phase D3 are complete. D3.29 (cross-category analysis) and D3.30 (Phase D3 closure) follow.

1. Anti-Pattern Name and Category

Name: AP-27: Forced Propagation

Category: Taxonomy Category 7 — Population-Scope Failures (Closing Anti-Pattern)

Register: Calibrated-Humility. Whether forced propagation actually occurs in population-scale FAI networks depends on governance decisions and organizational dynamics that are not yet empirically

observable; population-scale deployments do not yet exist. The architecture forecloses forced propagation by design. This note formalizes that foreclosure as prior art, establishing the architectural prohibition before the conditions under which violation could occur are realized in practice.

2. Description

Forced Propagation occurs when a contributing Self's governance attempts to condition FAI participation on the receiving Self absorbing specific governance patterns — schemas, orchestration substrates, rules, or other DNA-layer content — as a required outcome of FAI engagement. In this failure mode, the contributing Self treats what can only be an offer as though it were an obligation, structuring participation arrangements so that absorption becomes a prerequisite rather than a subsequent home governance decision.

The architecture is explicit on the point this anti-pattern violates. Paper 3 Claim 4 specifies the DNA evolution locus: when an FAI event dissolves, content propagates to each participating Self's home substrate per governance-configured ingestion at the home perimeter, and absorption itself operates through each Self's existing Paper 2 evolution mechanisms operating under home governance authority. The asymmetric ingestion property — that different participating Selves may take different things from the same FAI event under their respective home governance — is not a secondary feature but a named architectural commitment. It exists precisely because the architecture rejects any requirement of symmetric or compelled absorption.

At the population scale (D2.61), the failure mode's stakes become structural. Pattern propagation across a network of CKS-governed Selves is meant to be the cumulative result of many home-governance decisions, not centrally determined. What makes population-level collective evolution valuable — its capacity to preserve appropriate specialization while enabling voluntary convergence on high-quality governance patterns — depends on each propagation event being a genuine governance decision rather than a coerced one. Forced propagation substitutes coercive participation conditions for governance quality as the mechanism by which patterns spread. When this substitution occurs, the collective evolution architecture degrades into something closer to a franchise obligation model, where participation in coordination requires adoption of the franchisor's content.

The architecture forecloses this failure mode architecturally. D2.32 states the principle without qualification: absorption is always the receiving Self's home governance decision. A contributing Self has no governance authority over what a receiving Self absorbs. The only thing a contributing Self can do is make content available for absorption consideration; what happens to that content at the receiving Self's home perimeter is determined entirely by the receiving Self's governance authority.

3. Detection Criteria

Forced Propagation can be recognized through three concrete indicators:

FAI configurations or cross-organizational agreements with absorption-commitment provisions. The most direct form: the configuration governing an FAI event, or the agreement governing a cross-organizational relationship, includes provisions that specify what the receiving Self must absorb as a condition of participation. Any governance document — standing configuration, inter-organizational agreement, FAI event specification — that contains language treating absorption as a required outcome rather than a possible one is a forced-propagation indicator.

Standing configurations that specify absorption commitments on behalf of the receiving Self's governance. Standing configurations govern recurring FAI relationships (D2.21). When a standing configuration — authored, as it must be, as substrate content under home governance — purports to specify absorption obligations that the receiving Self's home governance must fulfill, it is encoding a forced-propagation arrangement. The governing test is not whether the language is mandatory or aspirational in tone; it is whether absorption is presented as a condition of continued participation rather than as a home governance choice made independently of that condition.

Conditioning future FAI invitations on demonstrated prior absorption. A subtler form: a contributing Self's governance adopts the practice of extending or withholding future FAI participation invitations based on whether the receiving Self has absorbed content from prior events. This converts the contribution-and-absorption cycle into an implicit compliance track. Whether or not the conditioning is explicit in any written arrangement, the practice structure enforces absorption as a participation requirement.

4. Governance Commitment Violated

The governance commitments violated by Forced Propagation are hierarchically ordered.

Primary: Paper 3 Claim 4 DNA evolution locus (D1.18). The DNA evolution locus is explicitly home-governed. The receiving Self's governance authority structure decides which DNA content from the shared substrate is a candidate for absorption, which is approved, and which is declined. The contributing Self cannot compel absorption at this locus; the architecture assigns no authority to the contributing Self over the receiving Self's home DNA evolution. Forced propagation violates this core Claim 4 commitment directly by restructuring the participation relationship so that the contributing Self's preference for absorption effectively functions as an authority it does not hold.

Secondary: Home governance sovereignty (D2.17, D2.43). The receiving Self's governance must have authority over what enters its home substrate. This sovereignty is not contingent on the receiving Self's willingness to participate in future FAI events; it is a standing architectural commitment independent of whatever coordination relationships the receiving Self maintains. Forced propagation arrangements remove this authority by making home substrate composition a function of external participation conditions rather than internal governance decisions.

Tertiary: Paper 1 Claim 3 (human-governed authority). The receiving Self's human governance must hold authority over DNA changes; the architecture's commitment to human-governed operation extends through to the evolution locus. Forced propagation bypasses this authority: if absorption is coerced by participation conditions, the humans governing the receiving Self's DNA are not exercising authority — they are responding to an external constraint. The governance is formal but not substantive.

Operational reference: D2.32 (pattern propagation mechanics). D2.32 explicitly identifies forced propagation as the anti-pattern and states the counter-principle: absorption is always a home governance decision. This note formalizes and extends that reference into the full seven-element structure.

5. Consequences

These consequences are stated in the calibrated-humility register. They describe what the architecture is designed to prevent, under the acknowledged uncertainty that population-scale dynamics are not yet empirically observable.

Individual level. Receiving Selves lose governance sovereignty over their own DNA evolution. Patterns they would decline under genuine home governance authority enter their home substrates through coercive participation arrangements. The practical effect is that the receiving Self's human governance retains nominal authority while the actual content of DNA evolution is constrained by external conditions. Human-governed operation becomes formal rather than substantive.

Network level. The voluntary governance basis of the collective evolution mechanism (D1.27) is undermined. The architecture commits to collective evolution emerging through governed substrate composition — the cumulative result of many independent home-governance absorption decisions. Forced propagation replaces governance-quality recognition as the propagation mechanism with participation-condition compliance. Patterns spread not because receiving Selves' governance authority structures found them worth absorbing but because the alternative was exclusion from coordination. The quality signal that is supposed to drive population-level convergence is degraded or eliminated.

Population-scale. A convergence-without-diversity risk arises. The architecture's design allows for specialization-preserving propagation: high-quality patterns spread to Selves whose governance authorizes absorption; patterns that are inappropriate for a particular Self's domain or operational context are declined. Forced propagation drives convergence irrespective of appropriateness fit. The diversity that should persist where governance recognizes it as valuable is suppressed by uniform participation conditions. At population scale, this produces a homogenized network whose specialization characteristics reflect power asymmetries in participation relationships rather than governance-quality-based adaptation.

6. Intra-Self Analog

There is no direct intra-Self analog for Forced Propagation. Governance patterns propagating between organizational entities under coercive participation conditions is specific to the inter-Self scope: it requires two distinct Selves, two distinct home governance structures, and a relationship in which participation conditions can be structured by one party and imposed on another.

The closest intra-Self scenario would be a governance authority within a single Self forcing directed-selection changes to DNA content without the appropriate governance process — approving absorption of content that the governance authority structure has not properly reviewed, or accepting changes through a pathway that bypasses established authority architecture. This is more accurately characterized as ungoverned DNA evolution (the territory of earlier Category 5 and Category 6 anti-patterns) than as coercive propagation between distinct entities. The coercion element — the use of participation conditions to override a separate governance authority’s discretion — has no intra-Self equivalent because a single Self has one governance perimeter, not two parties in a participation relationship.

7. Resolution

D2.32’s governance principle is the resolution: absorption is always the receiving Self’s home governance decision. The architecture forecloses forced propagation architecturally by assigning the DNA evolution locus exclusively to home governance. No contributing Self holds authority at that locus; the architecture does not provide a mechanism by which a contributing Self’s preference for absorption can become binding on the receiving Self.

For governance practitioners, this resolution translates into a clear set of permissible and impermissible actions:

Permissible: A contributing Self’s governance may make content available for absorption consideration. It may share the content through FAI events, describe the content’s provenance and purpose in the shared substrate, author provenance carry-over policies that travel with contributed content, and communicate to other Selves’ governance authorities why the content may be worth considering for absorption. All of these actions operate at the offer level; they place content within reach of the receiving Self’s governance authority without constraining what that authority decides.

Impermissible: A contributing Self’s governance may not condition FAI participation invitations — initial or continued — on the receiving Self absorbing specific content. It may not author cross-organizational agreements that include absorption-commitment provisions. It may not author standing configurations that specify absorption obligations on behalf of the receiving Self’s governance. It may not adopt the practice of extending or withholding future invitations based on demonstrated prior absorption.

The line between permissible and impermissible is not a matter of degree or tone. The test is structural: does the governance arrangement treat absorption as a home governance decision made independently of participation conditions, or does it treat absorption as a condition that the receiving Self must satisfy

to maintain participation access? Any arrangement that satisfies the second description is a forced-propagation arrangement and is invalid under the architecture's governance sovereignty commitments.

For cross-organizational agreement drafters and FAI configuration authors specifically: any provision in a governance document that links absorption to participation access — even as an expectation rather than an explicit requirement, even phrased aspirationally — is a forced-propagation provision. The appropriate form for expressing interest in a receiving Self's absorption is communication between governance authorities, not architectural conditioning of the participation relationship.

Category 7 Closure and Phase D3 Completion

AP-27 is the final anti-pattern in Taxonomy Category 7 (Population-Scope Failures). Category 7 has covered three failure modes at the population scope: AP-25 (Ungoverned Collective Evolution), AP-26 (Emergent Protocol Ossification), and AP-27 (Forced Propagation). Together they formalize the principal ways in which population-scale CKS-governed coordination can fail to honor Paper 3's Claim 6 commitments and the inter-Self governance sovereignty commitments that sustain voluntary collective evolution.

With AP-27, all 27 anti-patterns across all seven taxonomy categories in Phase D3 are formalized as prior art. The seven categories — covering Claim 1 through Claim 6 violations and population-scope failures — are complete. D3.29 follows with a cross-category analysis examining structural relationships among the 27 anti-patterns, and D3.30 closes Phase D3 with the full series summary.

Source Papers

Li, W. (2026). *Coordination Outside the Model: A Human-Governed Substrate Pattern for AI Systems*. April 2026. ORCID: 0009-0004-8065-3235.

Li, W. (2026). *The Instinct/Reasoning Separation Outside the Model*. April 2026. ORCID: 0009-0004-8065-3235.

Li, W. (2026). *Inter-Self Coordination via Shared Substrate / Full Aspect Integration*. April 2026. ORCID: 0009-0004-8065-3235.

How to Cite This Note

Li, W. (2026). *AP-27: Forced Propagation*. *CKS Derivation Note D3.28*. May 15, 2026. ORCID: 0009-0004-8065-3235.